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RESEARCH ARTICLE

Contemporary ‘Folk’ Dynamics: Shifting Visions and Meanings in the Goalpariya Folk Music of Assam

Simona Sarma & Anjali Monteiro

Abstract

Goalpariya music is a genre of folk music sung primarily by women. Common among the rural labouring classes, the songs deal with women’s desires, emotions, sensuality, and longings. Since the 1950s, major transformations have emerged within the performative space of the folk tradition, especially with the coming of Pratima Barua Pandey into this field. From an original mundane setting, Goalpariya music has now moved to an international musical performance context. This article explores this transition of the music from the ‘common folk’ to a ‘respectable’ platform. The article analyses how folk traditions may undergo a range of shifts to adapt to various social, economic, and cultural forces. Paradoxically, these transformations also lead to the emergence of a politics of authenticity, leading to a questioning of the concepts of tradition, authenticity, and cultural purity. The findings of this study are the outcome of fieldwork conducted in Gauripur and Guwahati in Assam, India.

Introduction

Initiatives modify the old, introducing the new ... The arts that performers and audiences enjoy are not exactly the same as those of the past, and nor are they all of the past. (Charsley 2006, 13)

The Goalpariya folk music genre (which combines both song and dance),¹ originating in the Goalpara region of Assam, contains several characteristic yet diverse themes, principally spirituality, longing, desire, and separation. Based on these themes, the songs and dances are categorized into different groups. Two important categories of Goalpariya *lokageet* (the Assamese term for folk music) are *bhawaiya* and *chatka*. *Bhawaiya* is a class of love songs, where the lyrics often express suppressed passion. The *chatka*, on the other hand, is short and crisp (Dutta 2009), with the lyrics usually sarcastic and bordering on parody. Two other categories are the *Kati puja* and *Hudum puja*, both of which are songs of worship.² These are ritualistic in nature and are exclusively confined to women. The basic instruments seen as essential for the performance of all of the folk songs are the *ditora* and the *sarinda* (both string instruments), the *dhak* or *dhol* (a percussion instrument), and the flute. These are

regarded as inseparable from the lokageet, as singers would not generally sing such songs without the accompaniment of these instruments.

Before entering the performative space that it occupies now, Goalpariya lokageet was restricted to the working classes of the rural areas in Goalpara.³ Bhawaiya songs, which are largely tied to the theme of migration, are a testament to this fact. Two important figures that recur within bhawaiya are *mahouts* (people involved in catching wild elephants and taming them) and *moishal* (buffalo herders), who formed an important part of Goalpara's economy. Given that elephants were an important symbol of power, the ruling classes had stables of them, used for ceremonial purposes. So, whenever the princes would travel to hunt for elephants, they would take the mahouts with them. For the mahouts, this became a form of livelihood that continued in a hereditary fashion. Accordingly, when they went away (often to Bhutan, which was close to Goalpara and is sometimes mentioned in the songs) to catch the elephants, they were unable to return home for six months to a year. Their wives, who stayed at home, would express the pangs of separation and loneliness through these lokageet. Hence, the element of *biraha*, 'deep emotion', comes out very strongly through such songs. It is particularly manifested in the elongated tones that the singers use, especially in the way that the last word of every line is lengthened with touching resonances. One can almost feel the throes of desperate passion, as the songs are replete with pain and longing. The repetition in stanzas, the tunes, and the expression all reveal a definite connection between the songs and the lives of those who sang them.

Apart from bhawaiya, the Kati puja and Hudum puja songs are also particularly interesting in the context of this study. As they are ritual songs sung only by women, men are forbidden from entering the performance space. Although the songs are devotional in character, they—and their performances—are filled with sexual or erotic imagery. For instance, the Hudum songs are performed to please the god of rain. The women assemble in an uncultivated field, especially at night, with a plough and seeds. They then shed their clothes, untie their hair, and dance passionately, all the while singing hymns to the god of rain. Through these performances, the women represent their own erotic desires as a metaphorical expression of the parched earth's desire for rain (Banerjee 1997, 155–56). Unfortunately, such performances cannot be witnessed now as the people who perform Goalpariya lokageet today claim to have stopped this practice altogether. One of the research participants, Swapan Sarma, now involved in keeping the folk tradition alive, commented in an interview:⁴

Hudum songs use very obscene and erotic words. It becomes a very different environment. The language used in such performances is such that it does not allow others to attend it. The overall get up is also not liked by many. Therefore it is now completely avoided. (24 June 2017, Gauripur)

This in itself is an important indication of the changes happening within Goalpariya folk tradition. There is a sanitization of the genre, with women no longer being allowed to practise some of its forms. With the onset of modernity, it has become difficult for the women to preserve and practise these traditional ritual performances. This clearly resonates with Sumanta Banerjee's commentary on nineteenth-century Bengal, where he discusses how the folk forms that speak

explicitly of women's desires (which usually originate from the lower-class, lower-caste groups, due to the moral sanctions on upper-class, upper-caste women) tended to get marginalized in relation to other genres as part of the sanitization process. He talks about how this marginalization continued during the persistent ideological campaigns of the *bhadralok*⁵ against these cultural forms, along with several socio-economic changes like the diminishing number of old patrons of this music and the rise of book culture (Banerjee 1990). Thus, it becomes extremely important to engage in what may be called 'song conversations', which allow us to critically interrogate the implicit sexual politics at work.

One of the fieldwork experiences also points towards the nature of changes that have been happening in Goalpariya lokageet. In the initial stages of this research, while identifying research participants and locating Goalpariya folk singers and musicians, one could see an automatic reference to people who identify themselves as Goalpariya folk 'artistes'.⁶ As a result, a majority of the research participants are folk artistes who now *perform* the lokageet at different functions and on stage, and receive remuneration.⁷ In fact, 'performance' has become a key to their economic survival. Thus, their engagement with the folk tradition has moved from its specific local environment to a much wider audience. In other words, the sample of this study itself reveals a shift of this folk music from its local space to a globalized context. This article thus traces mostly what happens in the modern performative space, as the local setting seems to be almost absent in the present scenario.⁸

This shift of a folk genre from a daily, mundane to a global, performative context becomes apparent in many ways. The timeline of this folk tradition is divisible into three phases. In the first stage, prior to the 1950s, in colonial India and immediately after independence, Goalpariya lokageet was largely confined to its original local site. During the 1950s, it began to enter the realm of the 'stage' and eventually radio, thus allowing for greater access by a non-local audience. Finally, around the beginning of this century, Goalpariya lokageet began to enter digitized and online spaces, making it a performative tradition with global circulation. Accordingly, the first part of this article deals with the changes in the folk form in connection with the forces of the liberalization of the Indian economy, the digitization of music, and the burgeoning of diverse performance contexts.⁹ This is then followed by a discussion of the several consequences that such changes have brought about and how the different stakeholders of the folk tradition have reacted to such changes. By looking at these transformations, one can locate folk music on a continuum rather than as a stable analytical category (Fiol 2017).¹⁰

This research, carried out from May to September 2017, mainly uses the framework of ethnomusicology. Using purposive and snowball sampling methods,¹¹ a total of fourteen in-depth interviews were carried out in two districts of Assam: Kamrup and Dhubri. Within Kamrup, the majority of the interviews were conducted in Guwahati—the largest city in Assam and the urban centre of the region—as most of the respondents now reside in this city. In the Dhubri district, the primary area where this folk tradition originated, some of the interviews were conducted in the city of Gauripur.¹² The fourteen respondents were involved with Goalpariya lokageet in

various ways. Five among them were singers (all female), five were musicians (all male), one was a female film-maker (who has recently made a film on Pratima Baruah Pandey), and three were men involved generally with folk 'preservation'. This distribution according to gender speaks of the sexual division of labour that is prevalent within the domain of folk music. Furthermore, the singers mostly belonged to the upper middle class category, while the musicians fell into the broad category of the lower to lower middle classes.

Emergence onto the 'Stage'

The initial set of changes started to unfold in the 1950s when the folk genre was transferred from its natural setting to the 'stage'. Although initially the performances were confined to Goalpara, gradually they began to be staged across Assam. With the technological revolution and the opening up of the economy in the 1990s, Goalpariya lokageet began entering the realm of the Internet, giving global audiences access. Throughout this process of reaching wider audiences, changes in the terms of performance, the manner of singing, the instruments used, and stakeholder involvement have become clearly discernible. The shift from being an integral aspect of the everyday experience, expression, and ritual performance of a subaltern community to becoming a performance by professionals for the stage marks a significant alteration in its contours and character accompanying its entry into diverse media of transmission.

The Classicization of Goalpariya Lokageet¹³

Pratima Barua Pandey (1934–2002), an icon of Goalpariya lokageet, is generally considered the first person who started to stage the lokageet publicly in Assam. As the daughter of Prince Prakritish Chandra Barua, she was a princess in the *rajbari* (royal palace) that was located in the city of Gauripur, then part of Goalpara. As folk performances by 'commoners' were part and parcel of the *rajbari* courts, Pratima Pandey began to listen closely and learn these songs. During an interview, one of her relatives, who is now involved in the preservation of Goalpariya lokageet, described how these songs of the *abhadra*, the non-respectable poor (i.e. those belonging to lowest classes and castes), required 'rescuing'. Although such patronage did help the folk music to move to different platforms rather than being confined to its localized context, the discourse of rescue needs to be problematized. It often takes agency away from the people from whom the cultural material is thought to need rescuing, thus making them mere puppets of the powerful Other. Also, in the process of this particular rescuing, the songs began to be associated with the royal family more than with the original performers. This led in turn to the making of a new kind of artiste, Pratima Barua Pandey, who was an individual interpreter rather than a hereditary practitioner (Weidman 2003, 203). Her father was the chief patron behind her successful career in Goalpariya lokageet. It was in 1949 that Pratima Pandey first sang

these songs on a public platform in the New Empire Theatre Hall in Kolkata; in 1960, the genre entered the realm of All India Radio.¹⁴

As soon as the songs reached a larger audience, Pratima Pandey's position in the context of Goalpariya lokageet changed significantly. The Assamese population across the nation began to associate her with the 'ideal' singer. Women from different strata and backgrounds, belonging to diverse communities, began singing the hitherto marginalized Goalpariya folk songs.¹⁵ Pratima Pandey, therefore, became an inspiration for many female folk artistes, as an icon and generator of the genre itself. Despite being an outsider in relation to the original communities, she was regarded as understanding this folk music like no other singer. In the present day, female performers try their best to sound as close to Pratima Pandey as possible. She set the benchmark for the way the lokageet should be sung, and even for the kind of voice that can and should sing Goalpariya songs.

As a result, the rules of the stage performances were more or less set by keeping her as the nodal performer. Emulating her 'thick' (deep) voice, singers with deep voices began to sing Goalpariya lokageet.¹⁶ In other words, her voice as well as her singing style eventually became naturalized. It is essential to recognize this 'politics of voice' where a particular kind of voice is valorized for performance in the public sphere (Weidman 2003). This also stems from the fact that 'thin voices are seen to be associated with "good girls" who are obedient, innocent, and pure' (Deshpande 2015, 25). Sanjay Srivastava (2004) has indeed suggested that the thin voice of Lata Mangeshkar (one of the most celebrated singers in the Hindi music industry) suited a particular vision of femininity promoted by Hindi films during post-colonial times to maintain 'Indian-ness' as separate from Western culture. Such notions related to 'thin' voices often led to the contrary belief that 'thick' voices command greater authority. The fieldwork narratives also indicate an effective function of this deep voice. For many of the research participants who were singers, this voice provided them with both authority and legitimacy, given the kinds of songs sung as part of Goalpariya folk tradition. In fact, several of the female folk artistes drew inspiration from Pratima Pandey and negotiated with the various power structures through their voices. As mentioned by Kalpana Patowary, a Goalpariya folk singer with a low-pitched 'thick' voice, it is the boldness in her voice that gives her the courage to be in the public sphere and have authority of her own. Therefore, this musical voice allowed them a space to resist gendered relations of power.

Apart from voice, the style of performance also began to change. In its everyday setting, the lower-caste, lower-class women would dance while they sang Goalpariya lokageet.¹⁷ Pratima Pandey, however, brought in the style of disciplined, organized, systematic performance, where sitting was privileged as against the traditional standing position. Similarly, the *dhakua* (musician who plays the dhol or dhak) Bimal Mali described how the style of playing the dhol was also different.¹⁸ It was taken on the shoulder and played in a standing position, in the traditional mode, as opposed to playing it while sitting on the stage with the singers. These changes can be seen as a form of classicization where the folk tradition was being transformed into an art form fit for upper-caste, middle-class family women. Pamela Moro has referred to

such forms of standardization and systematization as ‘cleaning-up’, before being promulgated widely (Moro 2004, 191). A similar kind of sanitization is also visible in the way some lyrics that were ‘crude’ and apparently vulgar were removed and replaced with something else (as mentioned by several of the research participants). In fact, they have been excised from the public domain to such an extent that the researchers could not locate any currently available examples. One of the folk artistes, a sarinda player, who hails from the city and now plays the guitar as well, commented how these changes were considered mandatory to improve the aesthetics of the folk form. The movement of song lyrics from being considered normal to being considered problematic within the same genre of folk music is an important marker of the extent of the transformation of this tradition.

At the same time, several narratives from musicians who played with Pratima Pandey (largely residing in villages) and other performers spoke of her dutiful and caring personality and emphasized her heroic character. The fact that her upper-caste class privilege benefitted her in popularizing the music is completely removed from the narratives. In fact, stories about how she resisted the restrictions placed upon her as an upper-caste woman and how she transgressed those moral boundaries are abundant. Several field narratives also underlined her courage in visiting the villages and learning the songs from the village women who were involved in farming, fishing, and woodcutting, despite being a royal princess. The research participants connected her *jamindari* background mainly to the barriers she had to face because of it. Her protest against society and within her home, for her music and for her lifestyle, was something that everyone dwelt upon. Such accounts seem to direct our understanding away from looking at her role and legacy merely from the perspective of appropriation.

However, because of the prevalence of such stories, the lower-caste, lower-class women (who, it must be remembered, originally sang the songs) have become invisible in the present context. Also, Pratima Pandey’s strategic removal of *Hudum puja* and *Kati puja* songs (for their explicit sexual content) from her singing repertoire is never discussed. Such selective choices indicate that the sanitization process begins with the initial movement of *Goalpariya lokageet* from the local towards the global.

Thus, we can look at Pratima Pandey as both disrupting or transgressing spaces (in the way she developed relationships with the people of lower classes and castes) and at the same time co-opting and sanitizing the genre. This paradox makes her an interesting personality to explore. By entering the space of this local folk tradition from outside and thereby taking the songs to a national audience, she creates a persona that comes into being in the newly emerging spaces of modernity in post-colonial India. This leads to the movement of this folk music towards a new trajectory.

Who is a ‘True Artiste’?

As already mentioned, an important consequence of such classicization was the surfacing of the title of ‘folk artiste’. Calling a performer a folk artiste automatically

began to confer a kind of authority, as well as a recognition of accomplishment. It also marked one's status and style (Fiol 2017). Terms such as this tend to bestow a form of professionalism that is not usually attached to folk performers. With increasing professionalism, the distance between the audience and the performers tended to grow. Such is not the case with non-professionals, 'most of who tend to be equals in the settings in which they perform' (Flueckiger 1996, 108). Conversely, in the setting of a stage, one invariably feels the authority that the professional artistes exercise. Hence, the stage brought in subtle forms of hierarchy that separated the folk performers from their audiences. However, despite this hierarchy—as reported in some of our interviews—the response of the audience began to play a determining role in the recognition of the performer as a 'true artiste'.

In fact, the parameters of a true artiste have now come to be related to how one performs on the stage and how one can tackle the problems associated with stage life. However, in order to become true artistes, several performers engage in a variety of practices designed specifically to develop good relations with the audience. In the current scenario, 'participatory music making' (Turino 2008) has become extremely crucial in an artiste's life. For instance, several of the Goalpariya singers, like Kalpana Patowary, now sing various folk genres rather than just sticking to Goalpariya music, to bring in diverse audiences who can take an active part in their performances. Such attempts at making the audience a part of the performance is seen as important and necessary for success and popularity. So the stage has definitely brought about changes in performativity.

Presentation to Representation: Becoming 'Cultural Exhibits'

Along with transformations in the norms of performativity, the stage brings new stakeholders into the domain of folk tradition, such as the organizers who are involved in the staging and management of folk performances. These organizers usually play a very powerful role in the representation of the folk genre. They especially control the stage performances by deciding who can sing what, how the performers should dress, and how they should appear while performing folk music in order to showcase a 'correct' representation. Such control also suggests the ways in which a performative tradition can transform from being quotidian to being utilized as a 'cultural exhibit'. Several controversies pertaining to the portrayal of folk music on the stage have recently emerged in Assam, which reveals the existence of such control. For instance, in December 2015, the All Assam Rongali Bihu Coordination Committee (which coordinates the celebrations of Bihu, a festival that marks the identity of the Assamese people) came out with a list of do's and don'ts that singers had to follow while performing Bihu songs and dances in the urban functions. There are instances where they even give a dress code that the artistes (usually female ones) need to follow. Such forms of control point towards the regional and sexual politics behind the presentation of a folk genre on stage, such that the encounter between tradition and modernity (in terms of on-stage representation) gets emphasized through the norms of performance.

Therefore, coming onto the stage means that the folk music is now removed from its traditional performance context and is re-contextualized in a setting in which it is merely representative on an external performative level. It is often the fear of extinction that makes folk performances the token for representing cultural identities on stage, such that the traditional performers may merely become 'elements in [an] exhibit' (Pillai 2006, 41). Such practices of tokenism are often initiated by institutions like the state and cultural organizations, for mostly touristic purposes. As is evident from this study, such open display for tourism often results in modifications to suit the interests of the organizers. One of the research participants, who runs a non-governmental organization called the Gauripur Vivekananda Club, is involved in showcasing Goalpariya lokageet on diverse platforms, based on the invitations and requirements of various sponsors and organizers. During his interview, he reported:

When we were working for ASEB [Assam State Electricity Board], then people from Denmark, the US as well as India had come to visit Gauripur. They were staying in the Circuit House and wanted to witness Hudum performances, as they had heard that Hudum songs are sung in order to bring rain during drought. As we cannot show Hudum the way it used to be done earlier, we had to improvise in such a way that the women brought from the villages to perform Hudum did it while wearing clothes. (Swapan Sarma, interview, 24 June 2017, Gauripur)

Thus, when these indigenous music forms are commoditized for touristic purposes, they take on an altered form. This account reveals the kind of objectification that ensues as a result of such modified depictions. It demonstrates how re-contextualized compositions or performances of local artistic practices can become a medium to express one's cultural identity to others (Fiol 2017).

Representation also means that there is now a fixed time limit within which one can perform Goalpariya songs. For instance, in most of the functions, the usual time given to different groups to perform their art is only seven minutes. By contrast, some Goalpariya lokageet, especially those taking the form of a story, would originally have been sung for around twenty minutes. Such time constraints have limited the scope of their performance, which then inevitably requires alterations on the part of the performers.

Despite these limitations, a crucial positive change has been the fact that several women singers have now taken up the playing of instruments, unlike in earlier times when instruments were primarily played by men. During an interview, one of the research participants, Punam Barua, a Goalpariya singer and the niece of Pratima Pandey Barua, sang while playing the dotora. Similarly, she also mentioned how, due to the several constraints placed on women who engaged in cultural activities (given that such activities required the women to come out of their homes and become visible in the public space), in some of the other Goalpariya genres like the *kushan* dance boys used to impersonate and dance as girls. With the changing socio-cultural environment, girls have now themselves come out to perform. Also, for many of the female folk artistes, performances on stage have proved to be life-changing, as they have given them the opportunity to express themselves and affirm their embodied identities. In other words, being physically present in the public gives

them a chance to reclaim their bodies and sexuality—something which had been previously denied to them.

Other Realms of Popularization

With the emergence of neoliberal capitalism in India from the 1990s, the music scene has undergone tremendous changes (Manuel 1991b, 347). The onset of economic liberalization in 1991 brought in novel aesthetic products like pre-recorded music on cassettes and later CDs. Such products, in turn, have come to imply new kinds of lifestyles. Also, the proliferation of the global entertainment industry has made people aware of the diverse musical traditions from around the world (Kvetko 2004, 184). Hence, it is now more than evident that in spite of its perceived seclusion, north-east India too has come under the ambit of the globalized market economy and the entertainment industry such that its traditional cultures and lifestyles have undergone important transformations. Some scholars are of the opinion that such a scale of commoditization of cultures may erase their traditional identities. However, other researchers, including Arjun Appadurai (1990), contend that globalization cannot be simply measured in terms of the binaries of globalism and localism (see Boro 2006, 14). One needs to locate the discourse of globalization within the complexities of the *interaction* between the global and the local.¹⁹

Hence, in its second phase, Goalpariya lokageet entered the medium of cassettes and later the Internet, especially with the rise of mass-media and information technologies. As Stefan Fiol (2017) has noted, the incursion of the folk tradition into these commercial enterprises has removed it from the spaces of musical and cultural evocation (rural life experiences) into the newer spaces of its production (recording studios) and consumption (given that Goalpariya lokageet is now consumed by communities within and outside Goalpara), both culturally as well as geographically.

Since the 1980s, the audio-cassette industry began to surpass both radio and records as a medium of music dissemination. The interviews have also brought out clearly how cassettes became a medium for different artistes to establish themselves in this new field of cultural production. They found that the release of cassettes garnered them recognition, which invariably helped them in getting concerts and shows. This further adds to Peter Manuel's discussion on the popularity of cassettes. In 'The Cassette Industry and Popular Music in North India', he argues:

While commercial Indian music cassettes began appearing in the early 1970s, it was not until a decade later that they appeared in such quantities as to restructure the entire music industry. In India as elsewhere, cassettes and players were naturally preferable to records due to their portability, durability, low cost and simple power requirements. (Manuel 1991a, 190)

In addition to the factors cited earlier, one can see how recognition through cassettes is another reason for the preference for cassettes over records. With the introduction of cassettes and CDs, the songs began to be recorded. Music recording also brought about further important changes in terms of the permitted time duration for different folk songs. It became mandatory to record a song in less than four minutes. As a result, the lyrics had to be compressed. One of the interviewees, who is now an

approved Goalpariya folk singer on All India Radio and has brought out a cassette of her own, mentioned how the compressed time meant a shortening of the songs such that their meanings become incomprehensible to the larger audiences. Thus, one can notice the grievances that some singers may feel towards the constraints of recording.

Fusion or Confusion?

In its third phase, Goalpariya lokageet has also moved to take the shape of fusion music. It is noticeable that most of the cassettes and recorded songs which have become popular show some degree of innovation. Usually, the music industry (which now includes the entire gamut of musicians, audiences, sound engineers, and festival promoters) stimulates such stylistic variations. Changes in audience aesthetics also push the performers to meet new demands. Peter Kvetko has connected the growth in Indi-pop with increasing levels of globalization and economic liberalization, mostly promoted by multinational labels like Sony and BMG (Kvetko 2004). The new artistes, therefore, often grow up listening to this 'mixed-music', such that they try to incorporate elements of that within their own musical practices as well. These several changes and effects have led to the constitution of a new kind of music that often utilizes folk music along with several other musical genres. This is generally dubbed 'folk fusion'. This phenomenon is also a result of the movement of some folk artistes between the Bollywood film music industry and vernacular small-scale industries. Fiol has termed this the emergence of a 'pop-folk aesthetic' (Fiol 2017, 6).

Nevertheless, there are several layers of complexity that underlie the word 'fusion'. An excerpt from one of the interviews may help bring out how fusion continues to remain a tricky genre even amongst those who are practising it. What follows is from an interview with Kalpana Patowary, a Goalpariya folk singer who sings various forms of folk music, contributes to fusion music as well, and is now also a Bollywood singer.²⁰ She says:

I wasn't much concerned with folk music, especially due to the tide of disco that came around 1983–84. When my father used to teach me folk songs while playing the dotora, I used to think, why is my dad teaching me all this? It is so deglamourized. At that time I listened to a lot of Shania Twain, Maya Karin, etc. Hence, there was a Western influence of jazz and blues on my songs. Gradually I started singing those glamour songs. But whatever came in front of me at that time, I received everything like water and sang it all. Women have that power within them, a characteristic to flow like the water and adjust to any situation. Many women have not realized that inherent power. But it is worth noticing that if I sing some songs of Maya Karin, I won't let it get affected by my Goalpariya style. I keep the different genres separate. Detachment is very important for versatility. Within that mixture, folk music became dominant for me. I was also a part of the World Fusion Music Festival. Interestingly, even after living there, I could not remove myself from folk songs. Now, if I show Goalpariya lokageet to you in fusion form without the traditional instruments, the audience will think that to be its original form. To avoid such misconceptions, I sing the folk song in fusion format such that sarinda will be played in an original way without any electrical intrusion. Singing differently is wrong. Although the rhythm has been slightly changed for the songs, I will not change the singing style. The *dhek* [voice projection] is important. All songs have their own *dhek* and we must keep that intact. Only then will the flow remain. Otherwise, I will be lost. I have to sing fusion without losing myself or it will

become confusion! Fusion music is very important if youngsters want to dance to some song. It makes the songs go global where one can go beyond the language of the music. (interview, 23 May 2017, Guwahati)

This anecdote highlights how singers create an unambiguous categorization in terms of deciding what elements of the folk music can or should change with the influx of technology. In this sense, folk music appears to have different kinds of elements, where changes in some elements are considered acceptable compared with changes in other elements. For instance, in this narrative, Patowary considers the change in rhythm acceptable, but not a change in the *gayaki* or *dhek*, the projection of the voice or the style of singing. Through her constant elaborations of 'how not to sing', it is obvious that she tries to justify the use of fusion in multiple ways. Her re-emphasizing of the importance of keeping 'folk sentiment' alive in fusion music reveals the complicated dynamic surrounding this music. Creating fusion music, therefore, has not removed questions of authenticity from the larger discourse of folk music politics.

Fusion also gets closely tied to the question of what instruments are used and modified to suit the fusion requirements. One of the research participants, a sarinda player, explained how he is trying to use this same instrument in different musical domains in an innovative way. For him, such novelty, which does not distort the songs *per se*, is acceptable. For him, it rather demonstrates how its tone is needed in other songs as well.

Thus, one can observe how singers and musicians often try to break with the conventional ways of performance by not fitting into the required mould, but rather experimenting with several elements at the same time. From Patowary's narrative, one can understand how she sees shifting from one folk genre to another and trying different musical forms as a radical act. It is her perception that women artistes have an inherent capacity to innovate and improvise flexibly. Folk fusion can, therefore, become a medium of resistance for some folk artistes. It also shows how the artiste's identity, which was perhaps formerly bound to the practice of a specific folk musical tradition, has become more fluid at the present juncture. Therefore, rather than sticking to the old forms of doing music, cultural artistes now want to experiment with the open-ended nature of folk music. Such endeavours provide them with a platform to move away from the old norms and establish alternative forms of folk musical practice.

Many of the research participants also felt that such changes were necessary in order to acquire more popularity and success and to make the folk form visible at the national level. Beyond the often-used term of 'appropriation' to refer to new performance contexts and performers, it is crucial to recognize that, in some of the cases, the tradition is self-consciously packaged by the performers for both Indian and international audiences to represent the region (Flueckiger 1996, 151). The availability of mass-media technologies like radio, television, and the Internet has now made such self-conscious endeavours both possible and expedient.

With the coming of digitization, folk music is going through further changes, as the Internet is becoming the primary means to distribute and consume music.

Digitization has brought about fundamental changes, with the lowering of barriers to production and distribution, increasing connection between producers, consumers, and listeners, and the rise of co-creation. The songs, given that they were passed on through oral tradition, tended to be inherently fluid, and the digital age is bringing that back. Goalpariya lokageet is now performed and sung by diverse people and is transmitted through media like YouTube and Facebook. Goalpariya lokageet has also entered the realm of Coke Studio,²¹ which is a music television series featuring performances of various musicians ranging from folk and classical to jazz and pop. This could, however, be seen as a strategy for preserving or ‘producing locality’ (Appadurai 1996, 178). In fact, these platforms can serve as avenues to keep the folk forms alive. Thus, with the spread of the global cultural economy, more than being merely a listening experience, music has become a spectacle to be visualized, enjoyed, and circulated.

Hybridity and Hierarchy

The onset of fusion has essentially led to a conversation between different elements and forms of music, resulting in the emergence of hybridity—in this case, a mixture between Goalpariya lokageet and other folk music genres, along with innovative ways of blending instruments and a mix of performance contexts. Most performances of Goalpariya lokageet now routinely involve the use of electronic instruments, complemented by two or three indigenous instruments. With the emergence of such hybridity, there has been an increasing trend towards claiming ‘authenticity’ and a heightened sense of identity with the use of Indian instruments and rhythms. Such instances of hybridity, however, often bring about new forms of hierarchy. For instance, there are power dynamics associated with musicians playing on stages during performances, depending on what instruments they play (whether folk or modern). Kalpana Patowary, while explaining this hierarchy, mentioned how folk musicians are often considered inferior to those playing modern instruments like guitar, keyboard, and drums. However, she affirmed that it is the folk musicians to whom she would always give support. She shows this support by letting them play solos during her concerts. This represents the adjustments the singers make to uphold the folk tradition while at the same time manoeuvring their work in keeping with contemporary requirements. The space of fusion music is a complex and contradictory one, where the singer might validate the elements of folk music within this hybrid culture and strategically deal with criticisms of being ‘inauthentic’.

Patowary’s language of ‘allowing’ instrumentalists to play solos also indicates the kind of power that the singer holds over the accompanying musicians.²² Such hierarchies may lead the musicians to disembodiment themselves from the instruments they play, where they try to see their talent as separate from their self. One of the musicians, who plays the dotora with Patowary’s team and is brought to various cities to perform with her, mentioned how the singer does not need *them* but rather their instruments. This highlights the detachment of the musicians—not from their

art, but from their musical selves—and is indicative of the level of self-esteem they possess.

In addition to the hierarchy discussed, hybridity exposes the flexibility of boundaries. With Pratima Pandey carrying Goalpariya music to diverse locales and stages, the character of that folk genre, along with those who perform it, has undergone several changes. As we have seen, various non-traditional and new performance contexts and participants have emerged. This is particularly important in the case of Goalpariya lokageet, because it gained prominence due to its intrinsic connection with the region and space of its origin. However, these novel developments have led to an expansion of its social and geographical boundaries.²³ In other words, through the varied performances, one can gauge the shifting boundaries of 'folklore region' and 'folklore community' (Flueckiger 1996, 197).

Who can Take 'The Stage': Negating Artistic Recognition and Livelihood Issues

Such shifting of boundaries often results in varying notions of which music belongs to whom and also who has the right, or who is even able, to perform and innovate a musical tradition. Taking these further, one arrives at the question of who has the power and opportunity to access this larger platform and display themselves. These questions underscore the power relations inherent within the process of representation, such that only a select few get the chance to take the stage and become popular, based on the kinds of social and cultural capital they possess. Tied to this, it is also important to look critically at who remains at the forefront of the stage. The very fact that Pratima Pandey (an upper-caste, upper-class woman from a royal family) was the one to bring Goalpariya lokageet onto the stage speaks plainly of such power relations.

The emergence of these new forms of music, therefore, brings us to some critical questions, such as which artistes gain visibility and which artistes are losing their livelihoods? Also, who can even afford to switch livelihoods? It has been seen that for many of the folk performers, who have mostly kept to the 'original' folk form with the hope of preserving the culture, the professional opportunities are dwindling. Several artistes, who have made a big contribution to the field, are today unable to garner aesthetic appreciation or social recognition. Their identity as artistes or as performers is seldom given importance. On the other hand, those who have moulded the music in a way that attracts a larger audience and have switched to fusion forms are in a better position economically. In other words, the experiences of the people from whom the songs have emerged and their practice of local forms have almost become invisible, while they themselves remain disadvantaged and disenfranchised. But does this mean change is the only way out?

For instance, the dhakua who used to play the dhak with Pratima Pandey is now living an impoverished life. While talking about his current engagement with Goalpariya lokageet, he mentioned how he performs whenever someone invites him. This shows that his precariousness has introduced the element of flexibility into his art. In fact, due to the pressures of earning a livelihood, folk-song performances have

now become more of a medium through which to earn an income rather than an art form. Despite such tough living conditions, however, the traditional artistes want to stick to their profession, as, in their words, they are 'in love' with what they are doing. However, through the interview conversations, they contradicted themselves, saying that it is not a good enough income generator. Now, especially with the changes in audience perceptions and needs, their art has become even more difficult to sell. Thus, within these changing circumstances, it becomes necessary to locate their desire for performance within the larger discourse of power representation. The changing trends of music-making have introduced uncertainty and new forms of negotiation into the lives of some performers.²⁴

The Politics of Authenticity

In music, authenticity has generally been understood to mean 'historically correct' by the earlier folk music revival movements of the 1950s and 1960s (Schippers 2006, 337). The newer forms of the folk tradition, coupled with the loss of livelihood for many performers, have undeniably resulted in the resurgence of the issue of authenticity, especially regarding how Goalpariya lokageet should or ought to be. It was continuously pointed out in the interviews that it is not possible to sing Goalpariya lokageet by just learning one or two songs. Authenticity is connected to certain parameters, like keeping the emotion or sentiment associated with the songs intact, the ability to use the correct dhek or gayaki, and the use of original instruments. The politics of authenticity, in other words, often results in the fossilization of the style of the folk tradition.

Throughout all of the interviews, the question posed about the changes and transformations of Goalpariya lokageet invariably raised issues of authenticity and validity. One often tends to construe and imagine a 'correct' form of a folk genre. Such notions of correct form, which inevitably lead to the politics of authenticity, have mostly to do with objections regarding the distortion of the songs from the forms sung by Pratima Pandey. As she is the benchmark, everyone associates the Goalpariya style with her. In other words, changes were accepted as long as they were not distorting the way she had sung the songs, even though the songs were not really hers. Ironically, even though Pratima Pandey has been looked at rather critically for becoming the new norm, the analysis of changes in performativity within the folk tradition is mostly based on taking her as the benchmark. She has become so omnipresent that one cannot think of the Goalpariya folk genre separate from her. However, the main objective here is to critique the very perspective of looking at her as the reference point or taking her as the standard for traditional values. This contradiction has come about because of the impossibility of gathering much information about the time before Pratima Pandey. Hence, interaction with participants was necessarily limited to people who were connected to her in one way or the other. In spite of trying to get in touch with women who used to sing the folk songs in their day-to-day lives, it proved difficult to find or to reach such people due to constraints of the sampling method (given that the key informants directed us

towards the folk artistes mentioned in the previous sections). Hence, our observations are perforce from the perspective of Pratima Pandey being the traditional symbol, although we do not mean to affirm that she is *the* symbol of tradition.

Such claims of authenticity frequently lead to the constitution of an 'authentic artiste'. The artistes then try to justify their authenticity by pointing out the ways in which they are striving to keep the 'folk feeling' alive. Many also underline the importance of using original or 'pure' instruments. It is therefore fascinating to realize how certain instruments can also become symbolic of pristine identity. Some of the interviewees asserted that the guitar is not acceptable in Goalpariya lokageet because it is not an Indian instrument. Thus, it can be observed that the participants tend to relate each musical instrument closely to the space of its origin. Such claims to authenticity may lead to a privileging of the folk form that tends to emphasize the superiority of 'folk' over 'modern' songs. This then essentially creates a dichotomy between folk music and popular music—a dichotomy that is fundamentally sustained by the people themselves to negate any form of innovation or 'distortion'.

The Question of Preservation

Notions of distortion repeatedly brought up by the research participants during the interviews tend to emphasize the importance of preserving folk performance in its 'original' form. Often, these ideas of safekeeping are connected to the act of self-identification, such that 'folk validity' is seen as being undermined by 'objectification and potential de-contextualization' (Friedman 1994, 104).

By connecting folk music to one's original identity, the 'act of preservation' could be seen as a political act. On the contemporary scene, workshops and competitions have become an important means of promoting the preservation project. These workshops, run by several non-governmental organizations and other organizations, primarily aim to teach the correct form of the Goalpariya lokageet. They emphasize the fact that folk music, like classical music, must be learned. Such learning, and the manner in which workshops or teaching centres are organized to teach this particular folk genre, suggest a form of the classicization of folk music similar to that previously discussed.

Fixated on 'Tradition'?

Such steps towards preservation are marked by nostalgia for 'cultural purity' that often exists among people. One can also observe how the transition from folk to modern is, therefore, time and again seen as wrong or immoral. In discussing questions of authenticity, there was a reiteration of this from most of the folk singers who tried to equate 'folk' with 'tradition'. However, it is important to examine the fact that some of the traditions they referred to have only *become* traditions through the ways in which they have been constructed and constituted through several practices (like styles of singing, kinds of voices used, and manners of performance).

This politics of authenticity can thus be understood in the context of Eric Hobsbawm's theory of the 'invention of tradition', according to which tradition is a practice of formalization and ritualization, often referenced with respect to the past (Hobsbawm 1983). It then becomes pertinent to explore how the memory of pastness is invoked to construct the validity of the folk form. However, 'the problem of pastness itself changes as the modes of cultural reproduction change. As traditions become mass-produced, as cultural artefacts become commodified, as intimate performances become available to large audiences, the pastness of the present becomes itself a plastic relationship' (Appadurai et al. 1991, 22–23). Thus, one needs to recognize the 'politics of pastness'—the fact that 'the past is a social construction mainly, if not wholly, shaped by the concerns of the present' and that it is 'collective memory' that strives to keep cultural continuities intact (Coser 1992, 25 and 30).

In a post-colonial world, it is almost impossible to think of an autonomous or internally coherent authentic culture, as all of us now live in a world marked by 'porous cultural boundaries' (Rosaldo 1988, 87). 'Musical authenticity' therefore should be understood as a 'social process of continual renegotiation of the shared "truths" and canonical values of a particular musical community' (Way and McKerrell 2017, 6).

However, by critiquing such claims to authenticity, we do not mean to take the position of cultural relativism either, as we understand the importance of the struggle for identity assertion. People strive to keep their folk music in its pristine form so that they can engage in constituting a sense of a shared public. However, this politics of authenticity has been elaborated in this study to bring attention to the complex dynamics that surround folk music in general. Goalpariya lokageet has become the object of several contestations and struggles. In the process, the voices of those who originally engaged with it (who were perhaps never burdened with questions of purity, as most folk genres, being oral, are flexible and open-ended) have been silenced. Such silencing reveals the politics behind the claims of authenticity which further prevents us from drawing a linear connection between a folk form and cultural identity.

Also, as Arjun Appadurai et al. (1991) have pointed out, one should not assume a past simplicity and fixity of folk traditions. In fact, electronic recordings of folk music may sometimes extend the plasticity and diversity of expressive traditions (see Raheja and Gold 1994, 192).

Conclusion

This study has shown how Goalpariya lokageet has undergone changes due to new initiatives. As Smita Tewari Jassal has commented, rather than equating folklore with 'bounded, authentic and unchanging materials', one needs to look at its making and remaking in response to changing conditions (Jassal 2012, 6). Such modifications have, however, given rise to issues of authenticity with respect to how the folk songs should be sung. Although many female singers who sing the new forms of Goalpariya music often use them as forms of resistance to the conventional forms of

music-making, the broader narrative among most of the research participants was that of distortion of a given past. Interestingly, this 'authentic' past that is seen as being 'distorted' is actually a classicized and sanitized upper-class version of the real folk past which only dates back to the intervention of one particular elite singer in the 1950s. It is fascinating and revealing that the participants now have adopted this version of the past as their own.

Thus, it is clear that there is an aesthetic construction of the past in the way in which there seems to be a close association between Goalpariya lokageet and the politics of its correctness. However, all of these contentions demonstrate that what is defined as traditional or authentic is constantly in flux. It is something that is continuously negotiated and reinvented according to the present circumstances. The call for a pure folk form, achieved by whatever means possible, reveals the inherent politics that surround folk music.

Certain questions are worth considering here. Can there ever be an escape from the politics of authenticity? Is the *search* for authenticity itself a problem, or is the problem in the way that the *idea* of authenticity is constructed? Can just any form of folk performance be intrinsically connected to tradition? What is, or can be called, tradition? These questions are particularly pertinent in the context of oral traditions that are fluid. Moreover, there needs to be more consideration of these issues in the context of the complex power relations that occur in a post-colonial digital age. Answering some of these questions will also perhaps help us better understand the shifting terrain of Goalpariya lokageet.

Supplemental Material

Supplemental material for this article is available at: <https://doi.org/10.1080/0015587X.2019.1622923>.

Notes

¹ There are certain genres of Goalpariya music that are accompanied by dances, such as *chatka* or *hudumgeet* songs, while some others, like *bhawaiya* songs, need not necessarily have dances attached. This article's focus is exclusively confined to songs.

² Kati puja is the worship of Kartik, the god of procreation; Hudum puja is the worship of Hudum, the god of rain.

³ Historically, the socio-economic scenario of Goalpara was characterized by the dominance of land-owning classes like the *jamindars*, for whom the peasant farmers, elephant catchers, and cattle or buffalo herders would work.

⁴ Swapan Sarma himself composes Goalpariya songs and makes a great effort to keep the tradition alive today by doing performances on radio and television.

⁵ This refers to a specific class of British-educated upper-caste men which arose in nineteenth-century colonial Bengal. This class played an important role in developing certain common standards of behaviour, along with associated social and cultural aesthetics.

⁶ The implications of this label are discussed in the next section.

⁷ The word *perform* is in italics because it has become a *performance* only through the course of history.

- ⁸ Many details about the 'local ritualistic context' have not been dealt with, as the fieldwork took us only to the performative 'artistes' and spaces. In a way, this also points towards the changes that have made the local scene almost invisible.
- ⁹ During the early 1990s, the Indian economy underwent a number of policy shifts, which are largely clubbed under the liberalization–privatization–globalization model. The policies involved slackening of government regulations on finances, businesses, foreign direct investment, and abolition of the licensing system. These economic reforms caused several ripples within the socio-cultural landscape of India, opening up the country to a wide number of changes.
- ¹⁰ A detailed musicology of the folk form has not been touched upon. Specific interest in the accounts of Goalpariya folk artistes and in understanding the changes and transformations of their narratives was a further reason to only focus on the ethnographic context of the folk form. Also, due to time constraints during fieldwork, the performance space has not been dealt with in detail.
- ¹¹ Purposive sampling refers to a method where the sample is deliberately selected according to the judgement of the researcher, based on some pre-determined criteria. In the case of this research, participants were chosen based on their involvement with the particular folk genre. Snowball sampling, on the other hand, refers to the method where one research participant goes on to give the name of another person, and so on, such that a list of participants is formed.
- ¹² Originally, Gauripur belonged to the undivided Goalpara district, which was the westernmost district of Assam. It was only in 1983 that the district was split into Dhubri and Kokrajhar. After this division, Gauripur came under the Dhubri district.
- ¹³ The term 'classicization' has been used by Partha Chatterjee (1993) to refer to a deliberate and negotiated process of national cultural formation. It includes the practices of sanitizing and systematizing the arts to make them appropriate for the tastes of middle-class people in general (Moro 2004). Several scholars (Moro 2004; Weidman 2003) have used the term to locate the ways in which musical traditions of the so-called lower-caste, lower-class people were purified for consumption by the 'respectable' classes (e.g. by means of institutionalization; transformations in the role of patrons, performers, and audience; innovative forms of musical transmission), which in turn led to the construction of the notions of 'ideal womanhood' and 'Indian-ness'. Several of these studies were, however, largely confined to northern or southern India, without much attention being given to other parts of the country. It is hence important to look at how folk traditions of north-east India also underwent, and are still undergoing, such processes of classicization in order to establish their 'authenticity' among the several musical traditions of the country.
- ¹⁴ All India Radio is the state-owned radio organization that broadcasts radio programmes on short-wave frequencies across the nation.
- ¹⁵ Among the singers interviewed, not everyone belonged to the community or the region from which the folk music they sing originated. It was therefore of particular interest to understand why and how they became involved with Goalpariya music. This also reflects the widening of the folk community and even the 'folk region' which happened with the genre's movement onto a wider platform.
- ¹⁶ https://www.youtube.com/results?search_query=pratima+pandey+barua+songs
- ¹⁷ 'Caste' is not so much a category of differentiation and violence as much as is 'class' in north-east India. This is an outcome of the presence of several tribes in this part of country. However, as caste plays an equally important role in India in general, and is present nonetheless, one cannot negate it completely.
- ¹⁸ Bimal Mali is one of the most famous Goalpariya dhak players and has received several awards and recognitions for his art, including the Gadadhar Award and the Bhupen Hazarika Silpi Award.
- ¹⁹ There are diverse complexities and meanings that 'globalization' may encompass. Given the politics that may be associated with use of this term, our use of it is to depict the multidimensional flows and trajectories which have emerged in the new era.

- ²⁰ Kalpana Patowary is currently mostly engaged with Bhojpuri folk music. An Assamese folk singer formerly, she has now founded a jazz-folk fusion band of her own called the Voyage Band. They travel around the world performing in several international festivals, where she mainly presents folk-fusion.
- ²¹ <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gDOFDwgXrew>. This is the YouTube link to a fusion form of Goalpariya lokageet along with a Punjabi folk song in Coke Studio @ MTV, Season 3. Here, the main instrument of Goalpariya lokageet, the dotora, has remained intact, while other instruments like drums, electric guitars, and synthesizers have been used to present the song in a very different way.
- ²² It is often the case that most of the instrumentalists who now play with Goalpariya singers belong to the traditional spaces of villages where they grew up learning to play the instruments. They have either migrated to the cities in search of work or they have been brought out by some of the established singers. Most singers, on the other hand, belong to a diverse group now and usually hail from the cities. Such dynamics often result in hierarchy between the singers (who now perform in a very different context, typically catering to the middle-class urban youth) and the instrumentalists who generally remain in their shadow.
- ²³ Joyce Flueckiger (1996) has written about Chhattisgarhi folk music and how it has surpassed its original social boundaries due to several newly emerging performance settings.
- ²⁴ This is not to look at fusion music pejoratively. Fusion has allowed the music to move through time and hence attract a wider audience. Nonetheless, understanding the economic dimension is important in order to grasp the ways fusion may dis-empower some while empowering others.

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